

NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.

1NT Opening: 15-17 points

2NT Opening: 20-21 points

1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit

2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.

In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.

Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: North

Lead: ♥Q

Board: 2

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: East

Lead: ♠3

Board: 3

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: South

Lead: ♠Q

Board: 4

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♥

Declarer: West

Lead: ♦J

Board: 5

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6NT

Declarer: North

Lead: ♠K

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 9 6 3
♥ 9 3
♦ K 5
♣ 10 9 8 4 2

♠ A J 4

♥ A K 7

♦ 10 7 4 2

♣ K J 3



♠ Q 7 5

♥ Q J 10 8 5 2

♦ A 3

♣ Q 5

♠ K 8 2

♥ 6 4

♦ Q J 9 8 6

♣ A 7 6

West	North	East	South
	1NT	2♥	3♦
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by North			
Lead: ♥Q			

Partner's 3♦ bid shows a 5-card suit and is forcing to game. While 5♦ is possibly the best contract your double ♥ stopper should sway you to 3NT instead. This is the old "9 tricks are easier than 11" principle.

North plays 3NT. As expected, East attacks in his ♥ suit.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 6

Even if West holds both black Queens, (not likely), you can only finesse your way to 8 tricks. Since you need 9 tricks you must establish the ♦ suit.

If East holds both the ♦ A and ♦ K then you are going down, because they will win the race to establish ♥s before you can establish ♦s.

But when the ♦ A and ♦ K are in different hands you have a good chance for success; it depends on West having no ♥ at the time he takes his ♦ winner.

So you should hold up on the first ♥ trick and win the second. If East started with 6 ♥s then West will be out. So whether he wins his ♦ trick first or second he still won't be able to continue ♥s.

After your hold up West has no ♥s. If he takes the first ♦ trick he will have to lead another suit. You will still have a ♥ stopper for when East wins **HIS** ♦ trick.

On the other hand, if East takes the first ♦ trick he can certainly drive out your last ♥ stopper. But then, when West takes **HIS** ♦ winner he will have no ♥.

Finally, if East had only a 5-card ♥ suit, good defense would beat you. But they have to be sure West wins the first ♦ trick, and they might slip up.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ K 5
♥ J 7 5 3
♦ Q 6 2
♣ 8 5 4 2

♠ A 7 4
♥ K 10 4 2
♦ J 9 7 4
♣ Q J

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ J 9 6
♥ A 8
♦ A K 10 5 3
♣ A K 6

♠ Q 10 8 3 2
♥ Q 9 6
♦ 8
♣ 10 9 7 3

West	North	East	South
3♣	Pass	2NT	Pass
3NT		3♦	Pass
All Pass			
3NT by East			
Lead: ♠3			

Partner's 2NT opening shows 20-21 points so you know you want to be in game. To find out which game you bid a Stayman 3♣. Partner replies 3♦.

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You don't have a 4-4 ♥ fit, so you bid 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♠3. Your first problem is which ♠ to play from dummy. That is an easy problem. If you play the ♠K you might lose the first five or six tricks. If you play low you guarantee a ♠ stopper. North plays the ♠A and returns the ♠7 to dummy's ♠K. South plays the ♠2 on this trick.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 7

You need 2 more winners, and you need to get them before you lose the lead because it appears that South can cash 3 more ♠ tricks.

That means you need all 5 ♦ tricks. The good news is that the 5 missing ♦ s will split 3-2 about two-thirds of the time. The bad news is that they will be 4-1 about one-third of the time. Can you protect yourself against a 4-1 break?

Maybe and maybe not. If South has ♦ J x x x there won't be anything you can do about it. But if North has this holding then you can succeed if you play your cards right.

Did you like that "play your cards right" quip? First play a ♦ to your ♦K; both defenders follow. Next play a ♦ to dummy's ♦Q. South discards a ♣. You are conveniently in dummy so you play dummy's last ♦ and North's ♦ J 9 are caught in a pincer movement by your ♦ A 10 5.

It was important to play the ♦ s exactly as described because dummy had only one entry left, the ♦Q.

Suppose your first ♦ play had been dummy's ♦Q. You could make your contract if you play a small ♦ and finesse the ♦10. But at that point you wouldn't know whether the ♦ s were splitting evenly or not. You'd be risking defeat on a hand where everybody who played for the 3-2 split was making the contract.

By taking the **SECOND** ♦ trick with dummy's ♦Q the 4-1 split is exposed at the right time.

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ Q J 10 5 2

♥ 8 4

♦ J 8 3

♣ Q 9 6

♠ 8 4

♥ J 10 9 7 3

♦ 6 4 2

♣ K J 5



♠ 9 7

♥ K 6 5 2

♦ K Q 9

♣ 10 7 4 2

♠ A K 6 3

♥ A Q

♦ A 10 7 5

♣ A 8 3

West	North	East	South
			2NT
Pass	3♦	Pass	3♥
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by South			
Lead: ♠Q			

and set up three ♥ winners in dummy.

But they allow your ♥Q to hold the trick.

Now you are desperate. You need two entries to dummy, one so you can play ♥s to force out the ♥Q, and another to enjoy the good ♥s. One of these entries will be the ♣K and the second will have to be the ♣J. So you play a ♣ to the Jack and then you . . .

. . .

Lucky you. West held the ♣Q.

But don't get too smug. A lot of the plays work in these practice deals because they are set up to reward the correct Plan. In real life finesses only work half the time.

Partner's 3♦ bid is a transfer; you dutifully reply 3♥. Partner now bids 3NT.

Partner has just a 5-card ♥ suit. He doesn't have 4 ♠s or he would have used Stayman.

With no 8-card Major fit you pass 3NT.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♠Q on which East plays the ♠7.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 6

You might get one more winner from the ♣ finesse, but basically you are going to have to establish dummy's ♥s.

You don't have the entries to think about going over to dummy to finesse the ♥K, so you play the ♥A then the ♥Q, hoping a defender will grab their ♥K

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A J 5
♥ 7 5
♦ A K 7 3
♣ A J 4 2

♠ Q 10 7
♥ K 9 8 2
♦ J 10 8 2
♣ Q 10

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 6 4 2
♥ A Q J 10 6 3
♦ 5 4
♣ 7 3

♠ K 9 8 3
♥ 4
♦ Q 9 6
♣ K 9 8 6 5

West	North	East	South
1NT	Pass	2♦	Pass
2♥	Pass	3♥	Pass
4♥			
All Pass			
4♥ by West			
Lead: ♦ J			

You have 9 points, an invitational strength hand.
With 6 ♥s you transfer partner by bidding 2♦.
Partner replies 2♥.

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With 6 ♥s you transfer partner by bidding 2♦.
Partner replies 2♥.

Remember, you have invitational strength, so even
with a great trump suit you bid just 3♥. Partner puts
it in game at 4♥.

The contract would be 4♥ played by East.

West plays 4♥. North leads the ♦ J and South plays
the ♦ 9.

Loser List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total =
4Losers are as seen from dummy, the long-trump
hand.

You might get lucky in one of the black suits, but your best hope is that North holds the ♥ K.

You win the first ♦ and play a ♥ to dummy's ♥ 10, which wins the trick. You smile. Return to your hand
with the other ♦, then play your last ♥ to dummy's ♥ J, which wins the trick. But this time you don't smile
because South discards! North still holds ♥ K 9 and you have no more ♥s to lead for a finesse. Does that
finish you?

Never say die. Return to your hand with a black Ace and ruff a ♦ in dummy. Dummy's trumps are now
♥ A Q 6 and North still has ♥ K 9.

Back to your hand with the other black Ace and ruff another ♦ in dummy. Dummy's trumps are now ♥ A Q
and North still has ♥ K 9. Play any black card from dummy, then sit back and wait for your two trump
tricks!

Bad trump splits can sometimes be countered by a technique called a trump coup.

The coup is accomplished by ruffing to shorten the trump holding so you won't have to play trumps from that
holding.

Pretty much like this hand.

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 8 5 2
♥ J 10 4
♦ 9 6 2
♣ Q 10 9 4

♠ J 9 7

♥ A 5

♦ A K J 10 3

♣ A K 6

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K Q 10 4

♥ 9 8 6 2

♦ 5 4

♣ 8 5 3

♠ A 6 3

♥ K Q 7 3

♦ Q 8 7

♣ J 7 2

West	North	East	South
	2NT	Pass	4NT
Pass	6NT		
All Pass			
6NT by North			
Lead: ♠K			

your ♠9, pretending to hold just the ♠ J 9. But East noticed his partner's discouraging ♠2 and switched to the ♣8.

You try the ♣J but West plays the ♣Q and you have to win with your ♣K.

Your chances for success are slipping away and you are down to your last hope. Your ♠J is a threat that only East can guard against. If East also is the defender with long ♥s then he would also have to guard dummy's fourth ♥. In that case you could squeeze him. But there is one important play you must make for the squeeze to function.

You must play dummy's ♠A to unblock so your ♠J can be the threat you need. Then play the ♥A, ♣A and 5 ♦ winners.

If East has thrown the ♠Q you win your ♠J and dummy's two high ♥s. But since he probably held onto the ♠Q you just play a ♥ to dummy and hope all three ♥s are winners.

Since East had to guard both the ♥s and your ♠J, he was unable to do both, and the squeeze worked.

You were lucky it wasn't West with the 4 ♥s.

Because of his 3-4-3-3 distribution, partner chose not to look for a ♥ fit. If he had opted for Stayman the contract would have turned out the same. The 4NT response is quantitative, inviting you to bid 6NT if you have a maximum.

You do. 6NT.

North plays 6NT. East leads the ♠K. You will have to make an early decision on whether to hold up or not.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 5 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 11

Only one more winner is needed. You should play a low ♠ from dummy in the hope that East will lead the suit again, giving you a trick with your ♠J (you know East holds ♠Q). In fact, you should even give him some incentive to play another ♠ by dropping